States of mind

Wellbeing Ambassadors Programme: Newham Borough

Programme Outcomes Year 1-3



Year 1: Wellbeing Ambassador Programme outcomes

In the 2019-2020 Academic year, the following 10 Projects/ initiatives were developed by the Wellbeing Ambassadors Teams across 6 schools and colleges:

- A new peer support 'Pen Pal' project that engaged 40 students in writing to each other weekly to improve relationships and wellbeing.
- 'Decompression Sessions': After school stress reduction sessions for students who are struggling with stress and anxiety.
- The 'Self- Care' package initiative for sixth form students, to reduce anxiety and promote a culture of kindness and altruism.
- Mentoring programme: 10 Peer-mentors have been trained in Year 12, with the training designed and led by Ambassadors.
- Social Event: Ambassadors delivered a social event for Year 12 and 13 students to improve relationships across the year group.
- Talking Groups: 6 students have been trained as peer-support group facilitators.
- Wellbeing Ambassadors co-facilitated peer support groups as lunch time drop in sessions and within allocated tutor time.
- 'The Nameless Book' Ambassadors launched a call out for book submissions, to encourage students to speak about their experiences related to mental health and Wellbeing.
- Lunchtime wellbeing groups, open for all students. The groups focused on providing mindfulness and creativity tools for maintaining mental health.
- A new, weekly student bulletin providing students with a range of resources and careers information about alternative career routes, stories from different industry professionals and existing teachers, to provide a new resource to help students manage anxiety and fear about their future.

Wellbeing Ambassadors : Student Self reported outcomes

Personal Development

Young People reported that the programme has provided a range of positive outcomes related to their personal development.

1. Confidence
2. Improved Social skills
3. Enhanced Self awareness
4. Improved mental health
5. Improved Oracy skills
6. Resilience

See Appendix 1.

Skills

Young People reported that the programme provided them with a broad range of Skills:

1. Critical Thinking
2. Communication
3. Empathic Listening
4. Teamwork
5. Planning and Budgeting
6. Organisation skills
7. Empathy
8. Leadership
9. Teamwork
10. Creativity

Staff Observations: Benefits for students and the school community:

1. Increased dialogue and discussion about mental health.
2. Students feel more empowered.
3. Increased confidence and improved public speaking skills.
4. Improved behaviour.
5. Access to research skills.
6. Access to new strategies for improving student's wellbeing.
7. Improved understanding of mental health concerns.
8. Increased student voice around mental health.
9. More relevant mental health interventions.

Wellbeing Ambassadors: Staff Feedback

"The programme provides a robust research and evaluation model to assess the student wellbeing within the school and implement evidence based strategies with a measurable impact. This has significant benefits for both the students who are the Wellbeing Ambassadors as well as the whole school community."

Ben Webster, Deputy Head, London Academy of Excellence

"The importance of good mental health has always been a priority for the London Design and Engineering UTC and has been part of the college's Learning 4 Life programme ever since the college opened its doors four years ago.
It was a pleasure therefore to be part of the States of Mind training project this year as we had become very aware of the lack of training within our learner body. Whilst mental health is high on the college's personal development agenda, it was noted that despite support from the Chaplaincy and the trained Mental Health Lead, there was a requirement for learners to have training themselves in order to empower them into becoming peer buddies for those that are, perhaps, in temporary crises (as opposed to having long term mental health needs).

In order to continue providing a positive service for our learners (aged 13 to 19) it is vital that we plan ahead. I can see services becoming overwhelmed over the next few months / years and having our own internal support network will be vital. I cannot recommend the States of Mind programme enough and I look forward to continuing our partnerships into the next academic year."

Gloria Gold, Vice Principal – Personal Development

"The States of Mind project this year has laid the foundations for an even more transformative programme in 2020/21. Even with coronavirus cutting the year short the outcomes for the students involved in the project and the wider student body have been fantastic, with a much richer dialogue around mental health and genuinely empowering student led support measures. Next year the students involved with the project will be able to build on the legacy of this year's cohort and I am certain the students that took part this year will gain a huge amount from passing on the torch and training the new Ambassadors."

Alex Henderson, Deputy Head, Six21 (School21 Sixth Form)

Year 2: Wellbeing Ambassador Programme Outcomes

Students teams designed a range of evidence based interventions to support students mental health within their schools:

- A ‘Buddy System’ for students to practice listening skills and develop a mutual aid system within form times.
- Q+A events with past students to inform current students about wellbeing techniques and ways to manage their mental health during sixth form.
- ‘Trust repairing sessions’ with teachers, to resolve ruptures in teacher-student relationships and promote help seeking.
- ‘The power of questions’: a campaign to improve students' confidence in asking questions in the classroom, to promote learning and personal development at school.
- Wellbeing boxes: 3 boxes to be integrated into the school library, to enable students to ask for help more easily, recommend ways for the college to support students mental health more effectively and to submit creative submissions to create a student mental wellbeing book.
- ‘Reimagining success’: a campaign to explore alternative career pathways from education and address students fear of failure.
- Wellbeing check ins: a project to embed conversations about wellbeing into tutor time, to provide additional 1-1 support for students.

Additional Outcomes:

Peer led wellbeing sessions

Wellbeing Ambassadors used their learning and skills to deliver a series of online wellbeing education sessions with their peers. Drawing on their learning and the facilitator guide produced by States of Mind, they successfully piloted and delivered sessions within school time to support their peers to reflect on their wellbeing and develop evidence based tools to support themselves.

Student and staff collaboration:

In many of the colleges, school staff participated as co-facilitators in the project sessions,enabling close joint working with the States of Mind team. This has helped to develop student- teacher relationships and helped the students to think critically about challenges and opportunities within their college.

Early help resource:

The online resource that we have delivered to schools has been used as an early help resource for students who do not meet CAHMS thresholds but are in need of personalised wellbeing support. Some schools have also used the resources to deliver wellbeing sessions, led by staff, in form times, to further increase the impact in their setting.

This has shown that schools can use the resource flexibly within their setting and adapt it's use to meet their needs.

Selfology: Student Outcomes & Feedback

Our participant evaluation has shown that young people believe that the education programme is a valuable tool for supporting young people's mental health.

95% of students who used the online learning platform said that they would recommend the course to a friend.

100% of students rated the quality of the content delivered as 4/5% compared to other mental health resources.

Participants self-report a range of mental health outcomes:

- Increased confidence and openness when exploring difficult feelings with others.
- Increased self awareness and self-compassion
- Improved understanding of how to support others
- A more solution focused mindset towards mental health challenges
- Increased levels of empathy and compassion for others
- Feeling less loneliness and isolation

The course has successfully equipped young people with skills to manage their mental health, with young people self reporting the following skills:

- An understanding of coping mechanisms
- A greater awareness of the signs of personal distress and how to manage them
- Listening skills
- Meditation techniques
- Breathing techniques
- Coping skills
- Self compassion tools
- A more flexible and broad knowledge about common mental health concerns

97% of students said that they would recommend the Wellbeing Ambassadors programme to others.

Examples of Student Feedback:

“I never thought about how students can really drive change by highlighting issues and coming up with creative solutions. I love making new connections and this has been a great way to get to know others, who have a similar view to myself, and connect.”

“The team interactions when we got teachers involved in decision making made this project feel like it was actually making a change and providing solutions, and isn't just a group of students discussing mental health and not spreading awareness around or providing solutions.”

“I enjoyed the fact that I was provided with a safe space to talk about mental health within the school, I liked that I was being heard and that I could actually have an impact by helping others.”

“It allowed us to finally talk about things express ourselves without judgements. Something that some people may never get the chance to do. It almost tackles well-being issues before they even happen. And the skill we get is kind of like an boost of immunity against things like stress. It would also just create a better environment for everyone. If everyone knew a bit about relationships and emotions and self reflection, there would be problems to do with hurt and miscommunication.as people would be more likely to talk through hardships rather that internal suppressing their feelings.”

“This programme was a great opportunity to find out a lot more about mental health than what is just presented on TV. Also, having an active roll in ways of improving mental health for young people just like me, was really exciting and something that I'm grateful I took part in. if I could continue participating in this programme I 100% would! I recommend to everyone - you acquire problem-solving, communication and analytical skills as well as being shown the deeper insights of mental health.”

“I would recommend this programme because it undoubtedly helps remove stigma around mental health. Some members of the group haven't been used to talking about it so openly due to a taboo within their family setting and this has enabled them to open and break down any barriers which is unbelievably relieving.”

“It's a chance to develop teamwork skills, empathy and excellent communication of your personal ideas which you think are best and also actively listening to what others have to say”.

“It is incredibly fun and you get the chance to make a difference in your school. You also learn important skills such as organisation, leadership and communication skills.”

“It’s a great opportunity to meet new people and work as a team in order to work towards a common goal to try to help and improve others lives”.

Feedback from Senior Leadership:

“The States of Mind Wellbeing Ambassadors Project has been a transformative experience for our students and had a huge impact on the culture of student led wellbeing at our Sixth Form. The design principles employed in the programme ensure that students develop their knowledge, but also their ability to empathise and understand the impact of wellbeing needs of the whole school community.

The student-led approach places the responsibility for identifying and addressing the most pertinent concerns firmly in the students’ hands, ensuring the response is a tailored fit for their peers. It is such a refreshing and empowering approach compared to the top down, directive curricula and resources I have seen used elsewhere. I cannot recommend States of Mind highly enough.”

Alex Henderson, Deputy Head of Six21

“It has been a wonderful experience for our students to take part in the Mental Wellbeing Programme offered by States of Mind. The process which States of Mind has developed is rigorous and has benefits on several levels.
Firstly, the survey which is sent to the student body is an excellent way of collating student voice and identifying areas of concern within the student body. This information can be used not only by the team of student mental wellbeing ambassadors, but also by the Year Leaders and SLT to inform future practice across the institution.

Secondly, the students involved in the project are exposed to research methodologies and project development skills. They are required to analyse data, identify trends and key areas of focus, ideate and propose several possible actions, evaluate their own ideas and then develop a project to address the area of focus they selected.
Thirdly, it goes without saying that the students’ projects have the potential to make a very positive impact on the wider student body.”

Olga Markoulides, Vice Principle, NCS College

“We have had the pleasure of working with States of Mind since 2019. The Wellbeing Ambassador scheme has provide a unique wellbeing programme within our sixth form that has had a demonstrable positive impact on the awareness of mental health issues within the school and the empowerment of students to produce a research based action plan that is implemented and evaluated on an annual basis.

The Wellbeing Ambassadors learn a great deal from their training, including a sophisticated understanding of mental health but also on research skills, conducting a school wide audit of mental health and the project management skills of creating meaningful and sustainable solutions that are evaluated, with the learnings feeding into the actions for the following year. Our students who participated in the project were able to use their experience

to support medical related university pathways in addition to improving the wellbeing of their peers. We would highly recommend that schools participate in this unique and proven wellbeing intervention."

Ben Webster, Deputy Head of London Academy of Excellence

Key Learning from Year 2

Staff facilitation:

School staff can successfully work alongside students, with support from States of Mind, to develop evidence based innovations within their school setting. This opens a new pathway and method for a whole school approach to wellbeing that draws on research and students direct experience to inform the wellbeing provision in the college.

Self Directed Learning:

The online resources were well received by students, who developed a more expanded understanding of themselves and learnt tools to manage periods of distress in their lives . This approach helps schools who feel unable to meet the demand for support and can
act as a self directed early intervention programme for every student, to promote wellbeing in the long term as an alternative to more reactive responses.

Student facilitation:

Students are able to co-deliver wellbeing education sessions, sharing the knowledge and skills they developed from States of mind resources to integrate wellbeing education into the school curriculum. This empowers students as the experts and shifts the traditional
power imbalances that place young people as passive recipients of mental health education.

Student and teacher relationships were improved through the collaborative working relationships developed between staff facilitators and Wellbeing Ambassadors.

Staff reported that facilitating the programme helped them to develop a greater understanding of the issues faced by students and an understanding of how to support their wellbeing more effectively.

Year 3: Wellbeing Ambassadors Programme Outcomes

Staff facilitated the Wellbeing Ambassadors Programme and a number of projects have been developed this academic year:

- A student-led wellbeing curriculum to replace form periods, incorporating practices from Selfology and resources developed by students that focus on key issues of concern. Wellbeing Ambassadors piloted the curriculum with a whole year group and the curriculum will be embedded in the school timetable for the 2022-2023 academic year.

- A centralised Wellbeing Hub, hosted on Onedrive, providing all students with access to resources, apps and materials around key issues related to student mental health and wellbeing.

- An event, focusing on the impact of social media on young people's mental health and wellbeing, with resources and advice for students who are experiencing concerns about social media use and it's impact on their lives.

- A Wellbeing booklet, designed, printed and distributed to all Year Y12 students, containing a range of creative practices to improve wellbeing and links to organisations and resources that support mental health.

Staff Training Outcomes:

Staff are now:

1. Equipped with skills and resources to deliver ongoing mental health education sessions with groups of students in their colleges.

2. Able to develop safe and confidential spaces for young people to explore their internal experience and develop their self-awareness, confidence and self-esteem.

3. Have developed facilitation skills and ways of working therapeutically with young people, enhancing their ability to provide psychological support for their students.

4. Using the training and programme resources to provide 1-1 and group support Sessions.

5. Able to deliver a 10-week project-based learning programme for students recruited as Wellbeing Ambassadors.

6. Have the skills and confidence to work collaboratively with students to develop student-led approaches to improving wellbeing in their college.

7. Able to host conversations about mental health in a pro-active and engaging way.

8. Developed methods for incorporating student's views and experiences into their strategy for improving student wellbeing.

Staff Facilitator Feedback

"The feedback from the learners engaged in it was really positive. Not one of them had anything negative to say or said "I don't want to do this again". [The pilot] was delivered to 240 people, in 1 day, in 1 hour. We have it embedded into the curriculum from September, every other Thursday in their learning for life session. The plan is for it to be offered to the new Year 12 group."

"I think it has definitely had a positive impact on all of them. Some of them seem a lot more self assured and more willing to engage in conversation. The one thing I noticed in the sessions was that students who don't normally engage were really engaged and came out of their shell. In some of these cases these are people who have never spoken to anyone. They leave the building or go straight home. There are people like that in every year group. I would say since Covid that number of people has increased. I think it was not having a member of staff in the room and having that freedom to engage and not having to worry about what people think and another person showing interest in them and not doing it because they have to but because they wanted to. That's the difference."

"It's been so amazing. I have had such a lovely team, every session was really pleasant. We formed a really nice cohesive unit. The biggest successes we have done are making some really amazing posters dealing with mental health and self-esteem, they have gone on all the levels, corridors and bathrooms. They deal with mental health, imposter syndrome and self-esteem. They are also going to have 'Star of the Week' and positive postcards as that was one of the things that came out of the survey, to focus more on what students are doing well and that is going to hopefully help with motivation as well."

" I learned way more about the mental health of the whole cohort, so the mental health of everyone in the year. The survey was super interesting and pulling out the common threads, I found it really interesting and grounding. It was really pleasant to work with mature students, who applied for this as I got to meet students I would never usually cross paths with. It was amazing to have everybody coming together and uniting, they all have different strengths which was really nice to see."

" I think the students themselves have such a deeper understanding of the issues troubling the year and were thinking really creatively about how to tackle that. They were bringing in a lot of their own experiences and I think they learned a lot from each other and their own experiences. They also had to prepare some presentations and I helped them in their communication with SLT and they learned a lot about what it takes to actually bring about change in a school."

" I think they can be quite black and white when it comes to teachers and I think it opened up their eyes and helped them to build empathy and

understanding.”

Student Feedback

“ [The sessions] have allowed me to see things from a different perspective and understand that my reactions and behaviours are often based on past experiences. I am able to look at my past to understand why my present is the way it is. I feel a sense of comfort that I am able to do this.”

“I'm now able to distract myself from the world completely, and I feel like I am able to remain calm more frequently when practicing techniques we have learned during the sessions such as meditating.”

“These sessions have helped me understand why I might react and feel certain ways which I can take into situations where those feelings come up.”

“I've learned that everyone can benefit from self help resources and everyone's behaviour is a product of their upbringing/early life experiences. If we look at these experiences we can understand how to function in our relationships with people and understand other people's needs”

“I have learnt more about my emotions and why I feel certain ways. I understand what I am and am not in control of, which has helped me to rationalise my feelings.It has helped hearing other people's experiences and ways of responding to how they feel as I can learn from it.”

“I enjoyed the calm, fun and pleasant environment during these sessions. At times it didn't feel like I was at school!”

“I enjoyed the group environment and how it was not as intense because it was not just me and it was in a casual environment. I enjoyed the mix of reflection and discussion. I liked how not all the tasks were the same and it was a mix of personal and group work . I also loved the mindfulness drawing. It helped me ground and relax myself at the beginning or end of the sessions.”

Summary of Outcomes from Year 3:

1. Improvements in engagement from students exhibiting challenging behaviour

2. Improved relationships with school staff

3. Improved relationships with peers

4. Enhanced understanding and awareness of mental health issues and their underlying causes

5. Development of key knowledge and skills to improve wellbeing

6. Increased confidence and self esteem